



ruled class—the creoles—to assert their interests, not least in the face of Spain's restrictive control of South American trade and punitive taxation policies, both to the disadvantage of the colonies. In the short term, however, it was a reaction to Napoleon's invasion of Spain in 1808 and his deposition of the Spanish king, Ferdinand VII, in favor of Napoleon's brother, Joseph. In effect, Spain's colonies no longer had a legitimate ruler of their own, so it was their plain duty to become rulers themselves, at least until the monarchy could be restored.

While South American liberals saw Joseph as the harbinger of a new, more just social order in place of the absolutism of Ferdinand VII, monarchists in the colonies saw any such liberalizing tendencies as inherently destabilizing. The seeds of internal conflict were being sown.

### **Social revolution in Mexico**

At the time, Mexico, which was known as the Vice-Royalty of New Spain, encompassed an immense area that extended almost from present-day Wyoming to Panama and that included most of Texas. Events there took a different turn. In 1810, a priest, Miguel Hidalgo, appalled at the obvious inequalities of Mexico, led a popular revolution that ended the following year in its brutal suppression and Hidalgo's execution. Another popular

**Pedro I of Brazil**, whose coronation is illustrated in this painting by Jean-Baptiste Debret, was the son of the king of Portugal. He had been left in Brazil to rule as regent.

uprising led by a second Catholic priest, José Morelos, between 1813 and 1815 was similarly put down. When, in 1821, Mexico did gain independence, it was by force against more or less token Spanish resistance, and under the leadership of Agustín de Iturbide, a Mexican general who proclaimed himself emperor of Mexico the following year. His rule lasted less than a year. By 1838, Mexico had lost all its Central American territories, and by 1848, it had lost all its North American territories.

### **Gran Colombia**

Events in Spanish South America—which included the triple Vice-Royalties of New Granada, Peru, and Rio de la Plata—followed a very different course. The key figure here was Simón Bolívar. Born in modern-day Venezuela, he was a creole, aristocratic, and highly educated. He had visited Europe several times and was an enthusiastic supporter of modern nation-building on the model established by the French Revolution. He believed, in particular, that the diverse peoples and interests of South America could be brought together by the